

Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in Brighton & Hove, United Kingdom



Glossary — ADFS
<https://www.alliancefordignifiedfoodsupport.org.uk/glossary>



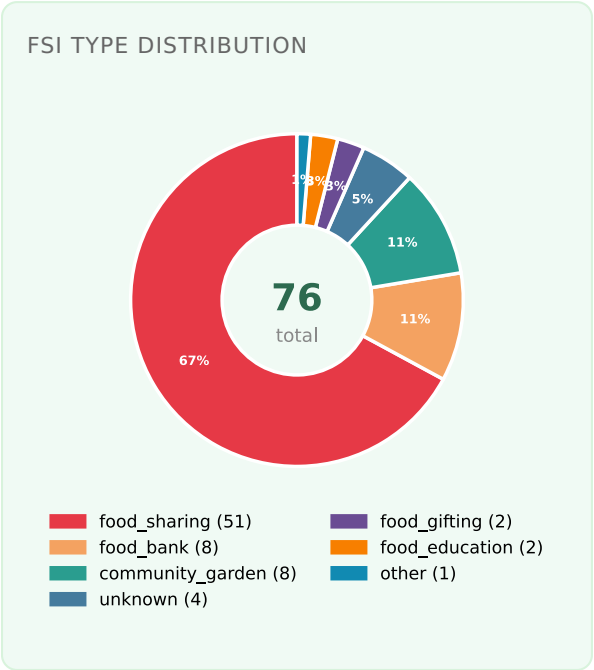
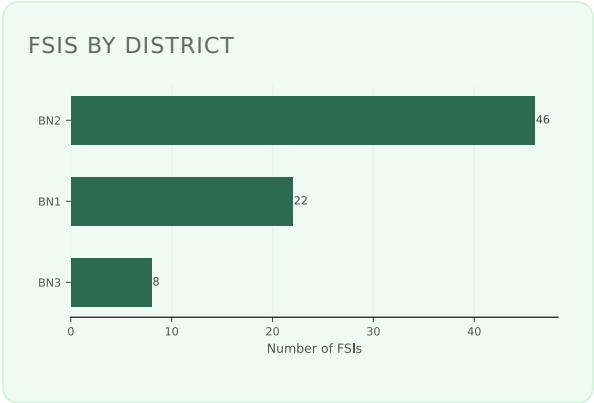
The Real Junk Food Project Brighton | Adam Buckingham
<https://restaurantsbrighton.co.uk/jobs/blog/the-real-junk-food-project>



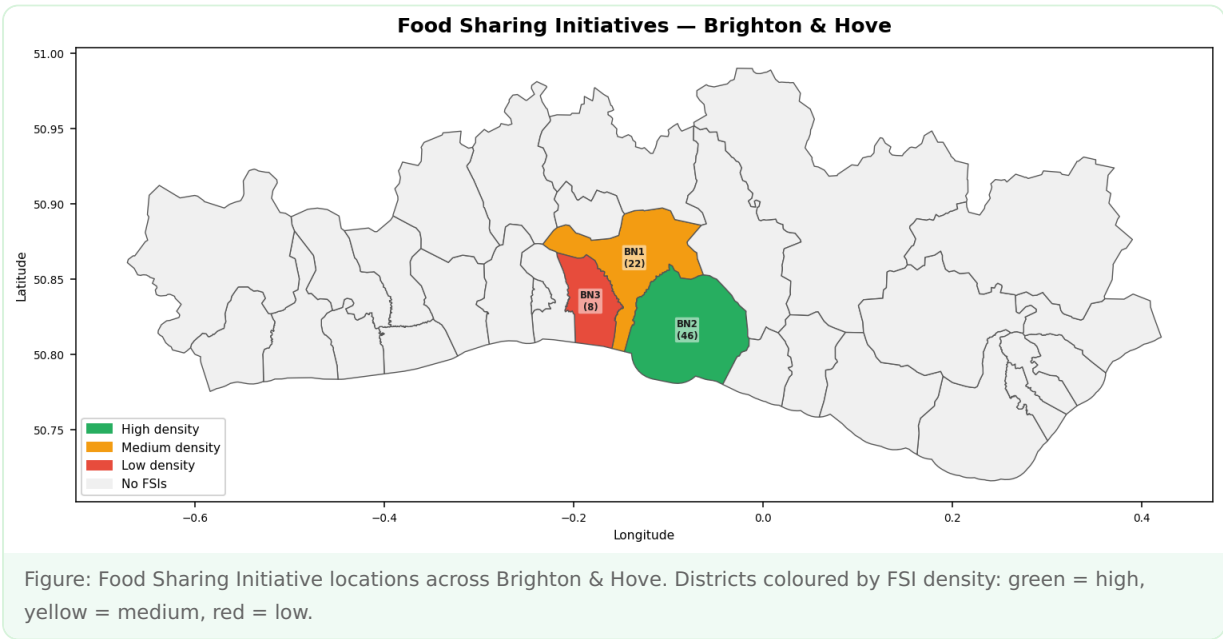
Food deliveries | The Network of International Women for Brighton & Hove
<https://niwbh.org/project/food-deliveries>



East Brighton Food Co-operative – Providing local people with fresh fruit and vegetables
<https://www.eastbrightonfoodcoop.uk/>



Geographic Distribution



Brighton & Hove hosts 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) across three postal districts, with BN2 (46), BN1 (22), and BN3 (8) representing the full district breakdown. BN2, designated as a green (high-density) district, contains the highest concentration of FSIs, accounting for 60% of the total, while BN3, a red (low-density) district, holds the fewest at 10%. No district in the region has only one FSI, indicating a minimum level of activity across all areas. The distribution aligns with official postcode boundary polygons, ensuring geographic accuracy in the data.

BN2's 46 FSIs far exceed BN1's 22 and BN3's 8, reflecting a stark contrast in initiative density between high- and low-density districts. BN1, classified as yellow (medium-density), hosts 22 FSIs, which is 29% of the total, suggesting a moderate but significant presence. BN3's low count of 8 FSIs, despite being a defined district, highlights uneven resource allocation or engagement. The absence of per capita FSI density data, due to reliance on census population figures, limits deeper analysis of equity in initiative distribution. These patterns imply that high-density areas like BN2 may benefit from greater infrastructure or community mobilization, while low-density districts like BN3 face challenges in scaling similar efforts.

Types of Food Sharing Initiatives

Brighton & Hove hosts 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with food_sharing initiatives comprising 51 (67.1%) of the total, followed by food_banks and community_gardens at 8 (10.5%) each. A significant proportion of FSIs—34 (44.7%)—incorporate sustainability-focused activities, while 36 (47.4%) integrate educational components, reflecting a strong emphasis on both environmental and social goals. Additionally, 40 (52.6%) FSIs organise events or workshops, indicating active community engagement. The dominance of

food_sharing initiatives suggests a city-wide prioritisation of redistributing surplus food, complemented by smaller but impactful efforts in food banking and community gardening.

Among sub-groups, food_sharing initiatives exhibit the highest overlap with sustainability and educational components, with 34 and 36 FSIs respectively, compared to food_banks, which show fewer educational activities. Community_gardens, while fewer in number, often combine sustainability with hands-on learning, aligning with their role in promoting local food production. Notably, 40 FSIs organising events or workshops suggest that initiatives with educational or community-building aims are more likely to engage in public-facing activities. This contrast highlights varying operational scales and priorities, with food_sharing initiatives serving as both the most numerous and the most multifunctional category within the FSI landscape.

Operational and Funding Models

Brighton & Hove hosts 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with 63 (83%) being community-led grassroots efforts, reflecting a strong reliance on local volunteer networks. Council-supported initiatives account for 6 (8%), while government-funded and NGO-led FSIs are minimal, at 2 (3%) and 1 (1%) respectively, highlighting a lack of formal institutional backing. All 76 FSIs operate on a non-commercial basis, with no initiatives classified as commercial or social enterprises, underscoring the voluntary and charitable nature of the sector. Notably, 27 FSIs explicitly mention crowdfunding or donations as funding sources, indicating a partial reliance on external financial support despite their grassroots orientation.

Among the 29 volunteer-based FSIs, 14 are informally run by community groups, contrasting with 18 that are formally registered as NGOs or charities, suggesting varying levels of organizational structure. The 9 FSIs employing a cooperative model represent a distinct subset, potentially emphasizing collective decision-making and shared resource management. Meanwhile, 15 FSIs are affiliated with broader food networks, which may enhance their capacity for collaboration or resource sharing. The absence of commercial enterprises and the dominance of community-led models imply that FSIs in Brighton & Hove prioritize social cohesion and localized solutions over scalable, profit-driven approaches.

Reach and Activity

Brighton & Hove hosts 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), categorized as high (20), medium (27), or low (29) activity based on quantified volume referenced (7,214 units of meals, kilograms, or members). High-activity FSIs account for 26% of total initiatives but contribute disproportionately to food redistribution, reflecting their focus on frequent, large-scale operations. Medium-activity FSIs represent 36% of initiatives, balancing reach and resource use, while low-activity FSIs, comprising 38% of initiatives, likely prioritize localized or niche efforts. Of all FSIs, 46 collaborate with farms, restaurants, or stores,

indicating a strong network of partnerships to source surplus food and distribute it efficiently.

Target audiences show distinct patterns: 47 FSIs explicitly aim to serve the general public, 38 focus on elderly populations, and 26 target children, while 18 each address low-income individuals and students. This suggests a broader emphasis on community-wide engagement compared to specialized groups, though initiatives targeting low-income and student populations remain underrepresented relative to their potential impact. The In the Bag Project, for example, reaches 10,000+ individuals through food banks, highlighting the capacity of high-activity FSIs to scale outreach. Conversely, the lower numbers for student-focused FSIs may reflect gaps in addressing food insecurity among this demographic. Collaborations with farms and stores, present in nearly 60% of FSIs, likely enhance resource availability but may also create dependencies on commercial partners for consistent food supply.

Digital Presence and Accessibility

All 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in Brighton & Hove maintain a digital presence, as evidenced by website data scraped from their online platforms. Of these, 35 FSIs explicitly mention online or digital coordination methods, suggesting a reliance on technology for operational management. Similarly, 35 FSIs operate from physical locations, highlighting a balanced approach between digital and in-person engagement. Only 15 FSIs provide details about operating hours or frequency, indicating limited transparency regarding the regularity of their services, which may affect user accessibility and participation.

The data reveals contrasts between FSIs with and without structured operational timelines: those listing hours or frequency (15 FSIs) may cater to more predictable demand, while the remaining 61 FSIs lack such information, potentially complicating resource allocation or user planning. Notably, 35 FSIs with online coordination methods may serve broader geographic areas or facilitate virtual participation, whereas the 35 physical-location FSIs likely prioritize local, community-based interactions. The absence of consistent accessibility features on FSI websites—such as language options or disability accommodations—suggests a gap in inclusivity efforts, despite the widespread digital presence. This disparity underscores the need for standardized reporting practices to ensure equitable access to food-sharing resources across the region.

Notable Initiatives

Brighton & Hove hosts 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in total, with the highest concentration found in the BN2 district, which alone accounts for 46 FSIs—nearly 60% of the total. BN1 follows with 22 FSIs, and BN3 has 8, highlighting a stark regional disparity in initiative density. Of these, 20 FSIs are classified as high-popularity, though the criteria for this designation remain unspecified. Notably, 36 FSIs incorporate educational components, suggesting a strong emphasis on awareness and skill-building, while 40 FSIs actively organize events, indicating a focus on community engagement and outreach.

Comparing sub-groups reveals that BN2's 46 FSIs far exceed BN3's 8, underscoring uneven distribution across districts. While 36 FSIs integrate educational activities, this figure is slightly lower than the 40 that organize events, implying a slight preference for event-based engagement over formal education. High-popularity FSIs, though numerically smaller (20), may represent a subset with distinct operational models or community reach. The overlap between educational and event-based FSIs remains unclear, but the data suggests that initiatives combining both approaches could be particularly impactful. These patterns reflect both localized efforts and broader trends in FSI design, with BN2's dominance and the prevalence of events and education shaping the landscape.